



Success at cricket became a measure of racial equality and political progress. At the time of their independence, many political leaders of Caribbean countries, such as Forbes Burnham and Eric Williams, saw in the game a chance for self-respect and international standing. When the West Indies won its first Test series against England in 1950, it was celebrated as a national achievement, as a way of demonstrating that West Indians were the equals of white Englishmen. Certainly Frank Worrell's ascension to West Indian captaincy was a landmark in the political development of the dominions that made up the side.

In a Sri Lanka riven by civil war, peace generally broke out when the national team figured in an important cricketing contest. The presence of Muttiah Muralitharan—the Tamil star of a largely Sinhala team—became a symbol of what was possible in that riven country. I sometimes think that if the Kashmir dispute were resolved, the only thing that might hold Pakistan together would be its cricket team.

But the truth is that compared to the great social moulds that shape us—class, caste, community, race, nation—cricket is trivial. Cricket creates no solidarities: it merely provides an arena in which to rehearse those solidarities as already exist. Before India became independent, Indian cricket obediently reflected every passion and prejudice that was current in colonial India.

Cricket gave the white colonist a way of asserting racial exclusivity in his all-white gymkhanas; it gave indignant Indians (Parsis in the first instance) the opportunity of showing that they were the white man's equal, given a level playing field, and, as Ramachandra Guha has shown in his definitive history of the Indian game, it allowed 'twice-born' Hindus to be bigoted in the matter of caste, dressed in cricketing whites.

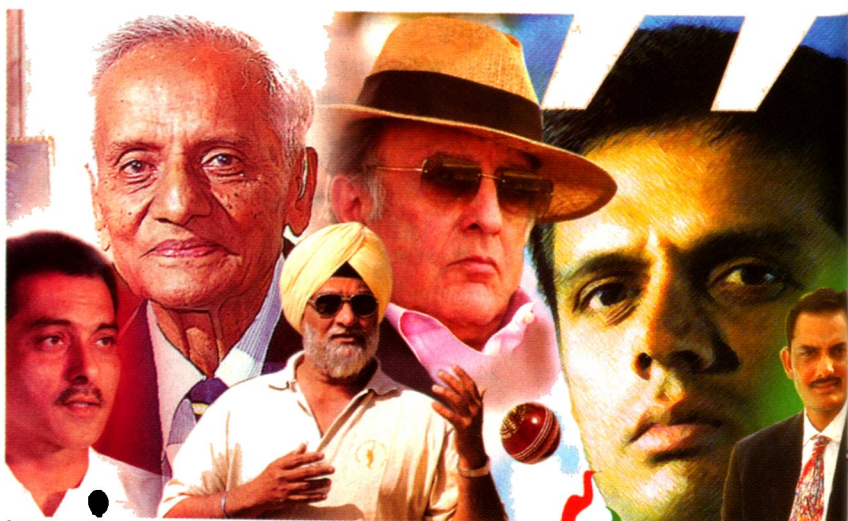
Anyone who hazily believes that cricket brings men together in common sporting endeavour should read Guha's harrowing account of the indignities Palwankar Baloo, the great Dalit left arm bowler, had to suffer at the hands of his 'upper caste' co-religionists, to play at the highest level in colonial India. Often the best players in the 'Hindu' team, Baloo and his brothers were grudgingly selected, denied captaincy and ritually humiliated by being forced to take their refreshments in the open air instead of the high Hindu air of the clubhouse. You could argue that cricket gave them a platform, they wouldn't otherwise have had, to challenge the exclusions and bigotry of caste, and that much is true, but that is true of every public arena subaltern heroes compete in: cricket can claim no special virtue.

Guha has shown us how cricket became an arena where arguments about defining issues like race, class, caste, religious community and nation were played out. The early dispute between the Parsis in Bombay and the white official class, about the right of colonial subjects to play cricket on public turf also claimed by polo-playing Englishmen, pushed cricket into the highway of Indian history, where it took on more and more passengers, some muttering about race, others about caste or community, all of them united by a shared passion for an unlikely game.

After India became independent, the domestic game was remade to conform to the ideological assumptions of a secular nationalism. In colonial times India's main first class tournament was the Pentangular, in which five teams defined by race and religion competed for the trophy: Europeans, Parsis, Hindus, Muslims and the Rest. Vijay Hazare, the great batsman and captain of India, played for the Rest because he was a Christian (his middle name was Samuel).

For Congress nationalists like S.A. Brelvi and M.K. Gandhi, a tournament that required sectarian teams and encouraged sectarian loyalties (the Pentangular, based in Bombay, drew vast crowds where Hindus supported the Hindu team

Indian teams have been models of republican propriety. The captains have spanned the rainbow spectrum of Indian diversity: Christian, Sikh, Muslim and Hindu.



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